Khrushchev wrote to Castro to persuade him that the agreement he had reached with Kennedy was in his own interest, as it provided "a guarantee that the USA will refrain from invading Cuba not only with its own forces, but with those of its allies as well." The main purpose of the letter, however, was not to inform Castro but to calm him down and stop him from acting in ways that might complicate Khrushchev's deal with Kennedy. "We would like to recommend to you now, at this critical moment, not to yield to your emotions, to show restraint," wrote Khrushchev. "It must be said that we understand your indignation over the US aggressions, and their violations of the basic guidelines of international law. But at present it is not so much the law at work as the recklessness of certain military figures in the Pentagon. Now that an agreement is beginning to take shape, the Pentagon is looking for an opportunity to undermine that agreement." Khrushchev asked Castro not to give in to these provocations.[7]

Shunned by Castro, Alekseev managed to arrange a meeting with Dorticós and Carlos Rafael Rodríguez, the man responsible for Cuban agricultural reform, to hand over the letter. "Unfortunately," said Dorticós to Alekseev, "the Cuban and Latin American peoples would perceive the decision to dismantle the special weaponry, relying only upon Kennedy's assurances, as a defeat for the Soviet government." The Cubans were disappointed, and Castro was struggling to find a way of calming his loyalists, who believed that the entire Soviet contingent was leaving Cuba. He wanted stronger guarantees and put forward his own conditions for accepting the Khrushchev-Kennedy deal. "Confusion and bewilderment are reigning inside the Cuban leadership," reported Alekseev to Moscow on the results of the meeting.[8]

The five points enumerating the conditions on which Cuba would accept the American pledge of noninvasion were broadcast by Radio Havana on the afternoon of October 28. They included an end to overt and covert attacks on Cuba, the cessation of the American commercial blockade of the island, and American evacuation of the Guantánamo naval base. The points were accompanied by a statement to the effect that orders had been given to shoot down any airplanes violating Cuban airspace. The Kennedy-Khrushchev deal included as a crucial component the verification of the dismantling of missile sites on Cuban territory. That component now